CINEMA ▼

PARTNERS IN CRIME

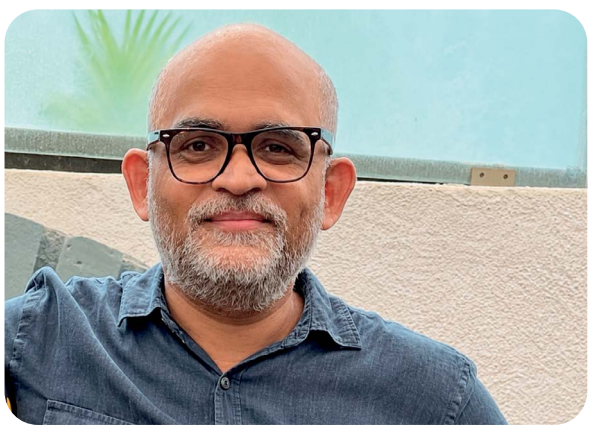
Manoj Bajpayee and **Neeraj Pandey** reunite for *Gajab Raat*, bringing back a creative partnership built on a shared desire to push boundaries



"*Yeh mere bina film banaate kaise hain?* [How does he make a film without casting me?]," jokes Manoj Bajpayee about filmmaker Neeraj Pandey. The statement speaks volumes about the rapport between the two, developed through the course of films like *Special 26*, *Naam Shabana* and *Aiyaary*. Last week marked the release of Netflix title *Gajab Raat*, their first collaboration in eight years.

Bajpayee talks of visiting Pandey's Friday Filmworks office whenever he is restless to converse as well as to have "free *chai*, free food". While Pandey prefers not to dissect their bond much, he adds that he is happy to work with an actor who has "the ability to summon talent at will". Bajpayee teases Pandey for being a taskmaster; Pandey quips that the actor is so busy of late that finding dates is a task.

In *Gajab Raat*, a thriller that unfolds over the course of a night in the capital, Pandey found a narrative that he and co-writer



Director Vinay Waikul had had enough of directing "serious" shows (*The Test Case*, *Mission Over Mars* and *Broken News*). It was time for a "genre shift", and in Amazon Prime series *Chaar Yaar*, he also found what he was looking for: something fun. "It's more a crime caper and the fact that I had never done one, that was exciting," he says. In the camaraderie between four young men—Saahil Shaikh (Purav Jha), Tony (Saqib Ayub), Jay Gala (Prayrak Mehta) and Sameer Khilji (Naman Jain)—he found a reflection of his own gang. Only unlike the show's quartet, which runs a car theft business and gets enmeshed in gang wars in Mumbai in the early 2000s, Waikul's was a life far away from crime.

He wanted to show the group's cultural-religious diversity. "Religion didn't matter then, what mattered was the person... These days, people shy away from that," he says. The show tries to capture the rise of an aspirational India after liberalisation. "Making money became more important," he says, "and it didn't matter what the means were to get it."

OTT ▼

BREATH OF FRESH AIR

Director Vinay Waikul is changing tracks from heavy material to *Chaar Yaar*, a romp through 2000s Mumbai with four young men who run a car theft business